

sketches of Yeniseian family (1996a), Ket (1996b), Yug (1996c), and Kott (1996d).⁴

Pulleyblank proposed a number of arguments against alleged Altaic affiliation, both phonological and lexical. Let us start with his phonological arguments.

a) Pulleyblank noted that many Xiong-nu words start with a liquid that was transcribed in Chinese with a consonant that he reconstructed in 1962 as OC *l-, and now reconstructs as OC *r- (personal communication). Pulleyblank noted that initial *l-* is rare in Altaic and initial *r-* is non-existent (1962: 240). However, this cannot be accepted as valid argument against Altaic affiliation of Xiongnu, since initial *l-* occurs rather frequently in some Tungusic languages and, more limited, in some Mongolic languages: cf. Ewenki *la:mu* "sea", *le:mba* "salmon", *lipki:-* "to stick"; Manchu *labdu* "many", *lala* "porridge", *laya-* "wither"; Monguor *lavci* "leaf", *lumu* "bow." Although initial *r-* is indeed atypical for Altaic languages, three major exceptions should be noted: a) secondary initial *r-* in Monguor resulting from elision of initial vowel (e.g. *rguen* "wide", cf. Written Mongolian (WM) *örgen* "id."; *ral* "river", cf. WM *aral* "island"; *re-* "to come", cf. WM *ire-* "id." (Todaeva 1973: 355–365)), b) secondary initial *r-* in Japanese resulting from the large influx of Chinese and Western loanwords (*rikai* "understanding", *rosoku* "candle", *raitaa* "lighter", *reji* "register"), c) secondary initial *r-* in North Korean literary standard, "reincarnated" from etymological spelling: *ryuri* "glass", *rodong* "labor", *ripyel* "separation" (cf. South Korean standard *yuri*, *nodong*, *ipyel*). Since we know nothing about history of the Xiong-nu language, initial *r-* in it (if it was initial *r-* and not initial *l-*), could possibly be attributed to similar cases.

b) Pulleyblank also suggested that initial consonant clusters represent a non-Altaic feature (1962: 240). Again, this is not necessarily true as secondary initial consonantal clusters (originated due to vowel reduction) are found in Middle Korean and in Monguor: Middle Korean *pco-* "to weave", *pstay* "time", *skweng* "pheasant", *psu-* "to use"; Monguor *ndige* "egg", *ndurda-* "to be-

4 My sincere gratitude to Ralf Stefan Georg who not only elicited certain Ket words from his informant, but also sent me some of his field materials on Ket that were also consulted in addition to the above-mentioned published materials on Yeniseian languages.